



Gharial

Gavialis gangeticus

male has bulbous tip on long, narrow snout



The gharial's unique long, narrow jaws—designed to make sudden sideways snaps at passing fish—make it instantly recognizable. It is more aquatic than its robust crocodile cousins and is highly adapted to move in water. Its rear feet are well webbed and the long tail has finlike keel scales along the top for powerful propulsion. On land, its limbs are not strong enough to lift its body in a high walk, so it pushes forward on its belly instead.

Females mature at eight to 10 years and are around 12 ft (3.6 m) long; males take another three to five years to mature and grow longer. At mating time, territorial

male gharials intimidate rivals and display to females with much noise and thrashing. The male's bulbous snout—locally known as the “ghara,” a type of pot—helps to make enticing bubbles to attract a mate.

Still on the brink

The gharial was on the verge of extinction in the 1970s due to habitat loss, poaching, and falling fish stocks. Captive breeding programs have led to more than 3,000 animals being released back into the wild since 1981, but the species is still critically endangered.

- ↔ 12–23 ft (3.6–7 m)
- ⚖ 350–400 lb (160–180 kg)
- ⊗ Critically endangered
- 🐟 Fish, waterbirds
- 🏠



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